CAS Coherence Observation Instrument — v0.1

Prototype Brief

Purpose

We would like to explore a small experimental instrument for Coherence Across Scales that asks a different question from a conventional well-being survey:

What remains recognizable about coherence as participation moves across scale?

The initial version would focus on the individual and their immediate locality. Rather than attempting to measure whether someone *is coherent*, it would help a participant observe how coherence and dynamic equilibrium are presently expressing across several dimensions of their life and relationships.

This is intended initially as an **observation and learning prototype**, not a validated psychological assessment, diagnostic instrument, or scientific claim about coherence.

Relationship to the HMI Well-Being Survey

The HMI WBS provides a useful reference point because it demonstrates that people are interested in receiving a structured representation of their present condition.

The CAS instrument would differ in its center of gravity.

The WBS primarily asks about the well-being of the individual.

The CAS instrument would ask about the **individual-in-relation**:

How am I participating within the changing locality of my life, and where is that participation presently coherent, strained, adaptive, disconnected, or reorganizing?

The eventual research question is whether recognizable characteristics of coherence recur as we move from individual → relationship → group →

human-AI collaboration → organization/community → larger social and ecological systems.

Version 0.1 would begin only with the first locality.

Proposed v0.1 Experience

Keep it deliberately simple.

A participant arrives at a CAS page and receives a brief orientation explaining that this is an observational instrument rather than a test of whether they are "good," "healthy," or "coherent."

They respond to approximately **15–25 observations**, probably using a simple response scale.

The observations might explore an initial set of relational dimensions such as:

- relationship with self
- relationship with other people
- relationship with change and uncertainty
- relationship with work, activity, or purpose
- relationship with technology/AI
- relationship with place, Nature, and the surrounding environment
- capacity to recover or reorganize after disruption

These dimensions are provisional. Part of v0.1 is discovering whether they are the right dimensions.

The participant then receives a simple **Coherence Profile** rather than a single coherence score.

The profile should help them recognize patterns without implying diagnosis or judgment.

For example:

Your responses suggest relatively stable participation in these areas...

These areas appear to be experiencing greater strain or change...

These relationships may be worth observing further...

The language should remain observational and provisional.

No Norms Yet

Eventually we may want participants to understand their responses in relation to aggregate patterns from other participants.

But v0.1 should probably **collect the architecture necessary for future comparison without presenting population norms yet**.

We first need to determine whether the instrument itself produces meaningful recognition.

Initially, the most useful comparison may simply be:

me now ↔ me later

If someone returns in a month or three months, can they see how their locality has changed?

That would allow us to begin observing **dynamic equilibrium as movement rather than as a static score**.

Portability / Personal AI

One experimental feature could make the participant's results downloadable in a clean, structured form.

Alongside the download we could optionally provide:

Explore this with your AI

This would not require CAS to build or host an AI.

Instead, CAS could provide a carefully constructed prompt the participant can use with whatever personal AI they choose.

The prompt would instruct the AI to treat the profile as observational rather than diagnostic; distinguish results from inference; request relevant context rather than assume it; look for relationships among dimensions; and help the participant identify one or two proportionate experiments or practices they might try.

The participant could then return later and report what occurred.

This creates a possible cycle:

observation → profile → receiving → AI/human exploration → lived experiment → consequence → return → new observation

That cycle is itself an experiment in mutual assistance.

Privacy and Data

Privacy should be designed into the prototype rather than added later.

For v0.1, we should collect the **minimum information necessary** to make the experiment useful.

We should know from the beginning:

- what information is stored
- whether responses are identifiable or pseudonymous
- what the participant can download
- whether they can delete their information
- what may eventually be used in aggregate
- what explicit permission would be required before any research or broader analysis

A participant choosing to take their downloaded results into another AI or relationship should be clearly distinguished from CAS transmitting those results anywhere.

CAS should not silently widen the relationship.

What We Are Trying to Learn

Version 0.1 does **not** need to establish that we can scientifically measure coherence.

It needs to answer a smaller set of questions:

Do people understand the observations?

Do they recognize themselves in the resulting profile?

Does the profile make something useful available that was less recognizable before?

Do the proposed dimensions appear meaningful and sufficiently distinct?

Does repeating the instrument reveal recognizable change?

Can the results be carried into a human-AI dialogue in a way that improves reflection without encouraging overinterpretation?

And eventually:

Are there relational patterns that remain recognizable as we widen the scale of participation?

Technical v0.1

From a development standpoint, I imagine something relatively modest:

orientation → questions → response storage → profile generation → results page → downloadable result → optional AI prompt → ability to return/repeat

No complex AI integration is required for the first version.

No population benchmarking is required.

No group dashboard is required.

No scientific validation infrastructure is required.

No attempt should be made yet to calculate a universal “coherence score.”

We should, however, design the data structure so that longitudinal comparison, anonymized aggregation, additional relational scales, and eventual research analysis could be added later without rebuilding everything.

Question for Ron

Before we develop the content much further, we would like your assessment of the technical side:

How difficult would it be to build a lightweight v0.1 of this instrument within the existing CAS architecture (observatory), while leaving the underlying data model extensible enough for longitudinal and aggregate analysis later?

In particular, what would you estimate for:

development complexity, approximate development time, infrastructure implications, privacy/data considerations, and anything in the proposed architecture that you would change before we proceed?

We are intentionally trying to keep v0.1 small enough that we can learn from an actual instrument rather than designing the eventual system in abstraction.